India Pale Ale

By Jaclyn Backhaus

Suggested Roles:
ACTRESS: *Boz, Deepa*
ACTOR 2: *Narrator, Iggy, Sunny, Tim, Vishal, News Reporter*

NOTE: This cutting asks each student to portray multiple characters, which is permissible for Nationals and SOME states. It may not meet the rules requirement for DUO in your state! Be sure to check your STATE rules before performing at local tournaments.

BOZ: **(Pgs 9-12)** *(digging with a small shovel and talking like a pirate)* It is oi, yer daughter Boz. I've come to share some news. I'm leavin to traverse the seven seas to head west to Wisconsin!

NARRATOR: Meet Boz, she's 29. She's a pirate, or at least she talks like one *(chuckles)*

BOZ: Oi want to open me own bar. Oi embark as Brownbeard, our natty ancestor, did afore me. Mannin the mutiny of that East India Company vessel 200 years ago.

NARRATOR: She digs a hole in the woodsy Wisconsin backyard of her parents' home – her home still because she is a Good Indian Daughter.

BOZ: *(puts her hand up, imagining protest)* No no, hush now mum, hush now dad. Don't afear. My bravery and your love will carry me safely . . . and this . . . a lost item of treasure. *(she spots a glint of white in the soil)* YEE-AOHHH – Jol's marble elephant *(reaches down and lifts it up)* Oim takin Jol with me . . . yaar!

INTRODUCTION

AS NEWS REPORTER 1: *We're visiting The Sikh Temple of Wisconsin in Oak Creek, where [insert number] years ago, a white supremacist opened fire, killing six worshipers and wounding four others.*

AS NEWS REPORTER 2: *The attack was declared a hate crime and a terrorist act by the U.S. Department of Justice. The shooting sparked outrage and grief within the Sikh community and led to increased awareness of hate crimes against Sikhs and other minority groups.*

AS NEWS REPORTER 1: *This community knows how easily fear of immigrants can turn into violence against immigrants, but they refuse to barricade themselves and hide. So, this Sunday,*

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just past the security cameras and the hired guard at the door, ***anyone*** *is invited to sit and eat for free.*

AS NEWS REPORTER 2: *This tradition of* ***langar*** *is a cornerstone of Sikh community life. All are still welcome here.*

ACTOR 1: *Meet the Batras, a Punjabi-Sikh family navigating tradition and modernity. As Boz Batra moves away and Iggy, her younger brother prepares for his wedding – this violent hate crime forces the entire family to confront their past and the uncertainty of their future.*

TOGETHER: *India Pale Ale by Jaclyn Backhaus*

A langar hall – like a cafeteria, but a little sparser.

DEEPA: **(Pg 19)** *(preparing food for the community with Boz and other family members; she speaks her mind to the audience)* Boz should be able to do whatever she wants! She's been saving money; it's her money. She opens a bar in a college town, she'll do well. She's almost 30. She should do what she wants to do.

IGGY: **(Pg 23-25)** *(off stage)* Ey boi, engagement day! BOI BOI BOI

DEEPA: *(to audience)* Ohhhh Iggy! He is crazy in love!

IGGY: *(as he enters; Indian boi street style, super amped on life)* My girls! So the plan is langar her, then we all go back to the Lovi's house; do the engagement party tradition thing, then later me and boys are goin out – bachelor party stuff.

DEEPA: Who is driving?

IGGY: Mamma, we take ubers! – Got to get you on that APP LIFE. Bozzy! You on that app life? You on Tinder, Bozzzyyy? Tell mama what Tinder is.

BOZ: Mamma, I'm not on Tinder. Oh my god, Iggy!

IGGY: Sorry, Boz . . . You like swipe to meet hot peeps and swipe to like reject peeps. Peeps do it when they are single and bored.

BOZ: **(Pg 26-27)** *(with a touch of pirate)* Look, oi don't need a man to be happy! *(SUNNY enters)*

IGGY: Bozzy is a 21st century feminist like Beyonce, Malala, Fiona Apple.

SUNNY: *(hugs BOZ)* I wouldn't have it any other way, daughter-mine. Yaar! Today we celebrate*! (claps his hands and begins to dance a traditional Punjab folk dance of*

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celebration with Boz, they hum, sing, clap)*

BOZ: **(Pg 36)** *(Boz stops dancing, catches her breath)* Dad, I'm not coming to the party tonight. I gotta go. *(deep breath, pirate affectation creeps in)* **(Pg 38)** Oim leaving. Oim moving to Madison to open a bar.

SUNNY: Basminder. You're not serious. You're going to walk out on your brother's engagement day? Leave your family? Why?

BOZ: Dad, my future isn't like up for your review. I'm 30 years old. I've been ready to leave for a long time.

SUNNY: **(Pg 39)** Basminder. We Batras. We don't leave it's not what we do.

BOZ: Brownbeard left. Jol left.

SUNNY: Don't talk about Jol!

BOZ: *(to audience)* **(Pg 41)** When Jol, my brother, crossed the sea my family was proud of him. **(Pg 54)** I was 14. It was like this freak accident; he was there as a tourist. **(Pg 41)** When he did not come back, we buried his memory under layers of dirt. **(Pg 39)** **(***to father)* Jol's coming with me. *(pulls the marble elephant from her pocket)* I dug him out of the back yard.

SUNNY: But we buried it for a reason . . . as a family.

BOZ: *(to Sunny)* It was supposed to stay underground, I know. And I'm supposed to stay here but . . . *(pause as she calls on the spirit with pirate accent)* **(Pg 41)** Brownbeard, oi call on you, on your bravery. Armed with my trusty talisman *(holds up elephant)* and my pirate sneer, ahead of me – a world oive never witnessed but in dreams! *(scene shifts-- Boz is behind the bar, serving a customer, TIM, a country boy of limited education)*

NARRATOR: **(Pg 42)** Now a year has passed. The bar is real and it is hers . . .

TIM: **(Pg 46-53)** So how long have you been here?

BOZ: Opened doors here just a couple of weeks ago.

TIM: Yeah, but I mean like how long have you ***been*** here.

BOZ: Oh, I moved to Madison last year. I was born in Raymond.

TIM: No way – you seem like you're from somewhere else.

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BOZ: *(staying cordial)* Born and raised in Wisconsin.

TIM: So, like, your family . . . what are ***they***? Where are ***they*** from?

BOZ: *(somewhat colder)* They were also born in Wisconsin. I'm 2nd generation American.

TIM: *(won't leave it alone)* And ethnically, like, what's your heritage?

BOZ: *(with a sigh, but trying to educate)* We're Indian. Religiously? Sikh from the Punjab province of India.

TIM: It's crazy how illegals, legals, you know, however you get here. It's like it's the country to be in, you know? I had this cousin, he met some Indians once and asked them where they were from and he was like "Dots or Feathers?" *(explaining)* Native American Indians and then like Indians from India. *(BOZ stares at him in disbelief)* Yeah, I though it was pretty offensive.

BOZ: Yeah.

TIM: *(trying to recover - awkwardly)* A lot of Indians becoming doctors . . . pretty big melting pot. The entire country, you know, it's like Hispanics, Black, Asians, you name it. White . . . You name it. Pretty diverse.

BOZ: I mean, I'm used to it because you know, I was born here. *(changing the subject)* One of my ancestors was a pirate. They called him Brownbeard.

TIM: No s***!

BOZ: He sailed on one of the beer ships between India and the UK. The East India Company were all basically pirates, but the main duty of the ship was to transport beer. That's where IPA comes from – India Pale Ale.

TIM: Oh, wow. India Pale Ale – India is the "I"

BOZ: The journey was so long they had to add extra hops.

TIM: I love IPA's because of their hops.

BOZ: Yeah, that's like what IPAs are.

TIM: I feel a little stupid askin you all about where you're from; thinking it's some exotic answer.

BOZ: I get that all the time. Like when you said "***what*** are you" – the phrasing implies that

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I am not human. I am an object.

TIM: I didn't mean. . .

BOZ: I'm not implying you said that intentionally, but it's just . . . problematic. I've dealt with people who actually meant it in a hateful way.

TIM: Wow. . . I know a lot a guys who might probably do that stuff.

BOZ: Well, as long as they're not creepy, bring em on by. We can have a nice little . . .

TIM: *(interrupting)* Teachable moment?

BOZ: My life is a series of teachable moments. . .

VISHAL: **(Pg 55)** *(bursts into the bar, frantic)* Boz! You gotta come home! Your brother told me to find you.

BOZ: Why didn't he come find me himself?

VISHAL: Because he's with your dad in the hospital. There was an accident at the ***gurdwara.********* You have to come with me. *(breaking down)* **(Pg 56)** A bunch of people were shot at services. My dad got hit in the leg; he's gonna be okay. But your dad. . . We have to go NOW. *(they exit in a rush – long pause, then Boz takes the stage alone)*

BOZ: **(Pg 67-68)** *(to audience, with great sadness)* A lone man, a white man, a man full of hate. A Saturday at lunchtime; services finish, langar beginning. Three assault rifles. Shot himself when he heard sirens, but not before he shot nine Sikh neighbors. . . my father too.

NEWS REPORTER: **[transition not in playscript]** The attack was declared a hate crime and a terrorist act by the U.S. Department of Justice.

BOZ: **(Pg 81)** I'm not going back [to the bar]. Ma needs me. She's all alone in that house now. *(long beat)* It takes a long time for us to say anything about anything . . .

NEWS REPORTER: **[transition not in playscript]** This community knows how easily fear of immigrants can turn into violence against immigrants, but they refuse to barricade themselves and hide.

DEEPA: **(Pg 80)** *(with much emotion)* We spend our time forgetting our stories, forgetting language . . . forgetting so they will call us American. And for what? I was born in this

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country. I'm as American as a deep fried apple pie. [But] it's easier to forget than to fear being killed. *(beat)* **(Pg 94)** It is a distinctly American tradition to let fear forge chasms. But we are you and you are us. What has to change in our society to allow you to love someone whose culture differs from yours -- who shares your patch of land, your earth? What has to change? . . . . What has to change?

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2020 National Qualifier
2023 National Qualifier
NIETOC

Traditional Punjab folk dance video can be found here
https://www.youtube.com/shorts/65d-Py2ARs8

****gurdwara:** *A Sikh place of worship, and it literally means "door to the Guru". It serves as a central gathering place for the Sikh community and is open to people of all faiths. Gurdwaras are known for their community services, particularly the free meals provided in the Langar hall, emphasizing equality*

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